

# Revealed!

## Secrets to Social Networking

There are two ways to look at social networking – use it for fun, as an extension of your college canteen, OR use it as a tool, to help you find better friends, make lasting contacts, work better, and gain popularity! We show you how.



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**S**ocial Networking, or to be more specific, online Social Networking as a concept was introduced to this part of the world in a surprisingly viral manner. “Hey man, are you on Hi5?”, was what everyone seemed to be asking each other, about five years ago. “What’s that?”, was a common response such a question would garner. “Don’t you know? It’s a web site, where you get to share your thoughts emotions, likes, dislikes, and pictures with people online!” Now some of us might have said, “But why would you want to do that?” – yet many took to it like fish to water. Such is the innate need in all of us to connect. Soon that Hi5 part of those questions got replaced by Orkut, by which time almost everyone had an account. Cut to today and people have migrated from Orkut to newer platforms like Twitter and Facebook. With Facebook crossing 500 million users and Twitter clocking daily posts in the vicinity of 65 million there’s obviously no escaping this phenomenon.

But are we using social networking the right way? You could use these tools to keep in touch with old school mates, comment on candid photographs of your friend’s last trip to Goa but that’s not all you can and should be doing.

Traditionally, in the old school world of networking people would (and still do) meet contemporaries at seminars and conferences for gaining exposure and staying in touch with latest developments in their

field. The world of online social networking too can give you a lot of exposure.

Apart from self development, even in the sphere of connecting on a personal level, there are things you can do to be ‘popular’, for the lack of a better word. Even in your experience you would’ve noticed some people are better at it. They get more ‘likes’, they get more replies and seem to have more ‘friends’. If you are scoffing right now about having more friends, we’d completely agree with you. Having more friends does not really make you better at social networking at least on platforms like Facebook or Orkut. But what about Twitter? Having tons of followers does give you access to a ready and willing base of people, who are eager to help you out. No matter how much you deny it, you do get tickled each time someone RTs (that’s re-tweets to newbies) any of your clever comments. It’s an ego boost, right?

### The virtual world today

At a day and age when much of our life is spent online, each of us has a certain amount of web presence. Initially when people logged on to the web and started interacting with people online, they were instinctively trying hard to be anonymous. We had usernames like “cyber\_evil\_dude666” and “vanilla\_bunny” populating message boards. Yes, message boards and forums were and still are the social networking tools from yesteryear. The only difference is that these are niche corners of the interweb, where like-minded people assemble for mutual benefit, exchange ideas, and well, do a bit of social networking, as we know it today.

In our local context we use Facebook, Twitter and LinkedIn most regularly. Even using these, there are ways by which you can meet like minded people, build lasting relationships, forward your career or business goals, and, using gaming terminology, level-up.

### Facebook

Compared to social networking web sites that have come and gone so far, Facebook has a relatively closed, privacy focused culture. People have the choice to reveal as much as they want to different sets of people and even the world at large. Even though Facebook as an entity may not like people sharing as little as they want, that’s what the culture has evolved into. Still, there are quite a few things you can do to work better with Facebook. By default, Facebook shows you feeds from people and pages with whom you interact with the most. This is shown under the banner of “Top News” when you click on the Home button. Facebook’s algorithms are not very good at judging which people you are most interested in. The other option then is to click on “Most recent”, which will get you the most recent feeds from all of your friends and pages that you’ve “Liked”. In practical usage you may want something in between these two options. A simple way to fix this is by creating a new list of friends, just for the sake of filtering content and not for privacy tweaking – which we will cover later. Say you create a list called “favourites”. Now in the ‘Most Recent’ drop down menu you can click on Favourites and only updates